

THE INCREDIBLES Rs 6,500 to Rs 10,000

This is the least populous category in our mega PMP shootout, and in some ways, the most interesting. Enter the big players—Apple, Sony, Samsung, Cowon, and Sandisk. This is a category where people usually shop for something very specific. You wouldn't spend upwards of rupees 6,500 on just "any" PMP now, would you? Prospective buyers tend to get very discerning here—they know their iPods from their Zens.

Features Drop-dead Gorgeous

If one player symbolises the catchphrase above, it has to be the Samsung YP-K3. We can guarantee looks from just about every non-myope around by simply taking this player out of your pocket. It's slim, it's shiny black with a classy looking chrome bezel, and the single colour OLED screen is ultra clear. Did we mention illuminated touch controls (another finger print and smudge magnet, though...)? While macho stereotypes are sure to call it a "chick-only device," we beg to differ. If the look is all-important to you, and you want a suave and sophisticated device, the YP-K3 is your answer.



If you're the sporty type, then you'll want to look at the Sony NW-S203F... another visual stunner. It's shaped like a pen, and comes with a holder / armband assembly that will keep it in place while you pump iron or try to burn away those tyres.

iPod nanos have been around a while, and we tend to forget just how stunning they look to someone who's seeing one for the first time. Slim and sleek seems apt—and light. Then there are the flashy colours that attract some and outrage others.

The other two occupants were relative plain-janes here—Cowon's Iaudio F2 and Sandisk's Sansa e250. The F2 is reminiscent of a tiny cell phone. The Sansa e250 has the best-built back we've seen—titanium alloy, absolutely scratch proof!

All That I Have

The iPod nano has never been conventional—in fact, Apple is all about a statement (synonymous with contra-convention)—the nano loses FM radio functionality. It also loses voice recording capabilities. Then there's the fact that the nano doesn't play video, and you can't use it as a pen drive. Shocking omissions? Let's see.

The Sansa e250 almost buckles under the feature load it bears—FM radio, voice recording, video playback, photo viewing, customisable equaliser and expansion... whew! Drop in a really good screen, and the Sansa is very practical. Another very practical offering is Cowon's F2, which has dual headphone jacks—what was that about the best things coming in pairs?

The Sony NW-S203F has only three equaliser settings; however, two of them are user-customisable, so you can save and use those set-

A Can Full Of Sound

If you thought headphones were just headphones, you're dead wrong. Portable devices are personal, and PMPs even more so. Remember, no two ears are alike, and choosing the right "cans" for them is no easy task. A pair of headphones has to feel comfortable, sound good, and look neat as well—in that order.

Headphones have been classically divided into three broad categories, which may have further subcategories.

Let's start small. "Earbuds" actually fit inside your ear and are typically tiny, and suitable for portable devices—especially PMPs. Earbuds also deliver sound right into your ears, and right on to your eardrums, which is why some love them, and others hate them. It's a personal choice, because some people find it horribly intrusive to have something poking into their ear canals. Regardless, this type of earphone is suitable while on the move, working out, etc., because of their size and the fact that they're actually anchored to your ears.

Variants of earbuds include in-ears, whose shape actually mimics the ear canal so they fit snugly inside your ear. Most of these feature soft rubber or silicone material to avoid irritation to the delicate insides of our ears. They're also called "intra-ear" headphones, earplugs, or simply earphones. They usually block out a lot of external noise.

The second type of headphones is the Supra Aural variety. Supra aural headphones just cover your ears; however, they don't envelop the entire outer ear. Some of the most famous names in the headphone industry, including Grado and Bose, swear by Supra Aural earphones. Due to their unique acoustic models, Supra Aurals are said to offer the best balance of sound (audiophile-grade sound), but some find the pressure they create on the outer ear and cartilage uncomfortable after a few hours. A more comfortable variety of Supra Aurals are the clip-on types, which don't have a headband for fastening. Rather, they have clips that hook on behind your ears.

This category also features most of the active noise cancelling models. They can be used for travel because of their size (they're portable), but they're not suitable for use while working out, unlike earplugs.

The third category consists of the biggest headphones called circumaural headphones. These are comfortable for most people, as they feature a large, heavily padded ring that completely ensconces the ear within. In short, they rest on your head and engulf your ears. They also have the potential for large drivers because of the sheer size. Brands like AKG and Sennheiser use circumaural designs for their audiophile range, though they have products in other segments as well.